

LEGISLATURE OF THE STATE OF IDAHO
Sixty-eighth Legislature Second Regular Session - 2026

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

HOUSE BILL NO. 577

BY TRANSPORTATION AND DEFENSE COMMITTEE

AN ACT

RELATING TO LICENSE PLATES; AMENDING SECTION 49-443, IDAHO CODE, TO REVISE PROVISIONS REGARDING THE EXPIRATION OF LICENSE PLATES AND TO MAKE TECHNICAL CORRECTIONS; AMENDING SECTION 49-443B, IDAHO CODE, TO PROVIDE FOR THE VALIDITY OF CERTAIN LICENSE PLATES ON STATE VEHICLES AND VEHICLES BELONGING TO TAXING DISTRICTS; AND DECLARING AN EMERGENCY AND PROVIDING AN EFFECTIVE DATE.

Be It Enacted by the Legislature of the State of Idaho:

SECTION 1. That Section 49-443, Idaho Code, be, and the same is hereby amended to read as follows:

49-443. LICENSE PLATES TO BE FURNISHED BY DEPARTMENT -- FORM AND CONTENTS. (1) The assessor or the department shall furnish to every owner whose vehicle is registered or licensed by that office, pursuant to sections 49-402 and 49-402A, Idaho Code, one (1) license plate for vehicles registered under the provisions of section 49-406, 49-406A or 49-408, Idaho Code, or a motorcycle, trailer, truck-tractor, or semitrailer; one (1) restricted vehicle license plate for all-terrain vehicles, utility type vehicles and motorbikes licensed pursuant to this chapter; and two (2) license plates for every other motor vehicle. If a vehicle is issued one (1) plate only, that plate shall be displayed in accordance with the provisions of section 49-428, Idaho Code. For vehicles registered under the provisions of section 49-407, Idaho Code, the applicant shall provide one (1) plate to be displayed on the rear of the vehicle.

(a) Commencing January 1, 1992, the color and design of the plates shall be comparable to the color and design of the statehood centennial issue of license plates with blue numerals and letters on a multicolored red, white and blue background. Each license plate must bear ~~upon~~ on its face the inscriptions "Famous Potatoes" and "Scenic Idaho." The restricted vehicle license plate for all-terrain vehicles, utility type vehicles and motorbikes shall be a white background with black numerals and letters, with "Idaho Restricted Vehicle" and ~~the year of its expiration on its face and~~ no other inscription. The restricted vehicle license plate shall be the same size required for the motorcycle license plate.

(b) Every license plate shall have displayed ~~upon~~ on it the registration number assigned to the vehicle and its owner and the name "Idaho," which may be abbreviated. The plates issued under the provisions of section 49-402(1), Idaho Code, and the required letters and numerals, including an identification of the county in which the motor vehicle to which the plates will be affixed is registered, shall be of sufficient size to be plainly readable from a distance of seventy-five (75) feet during daylight, and each license plate and registration sticker shall

1 be treated with a fully reflectorized material according to specifica-
2 tions prescribed by the board.

3 (2) License plates shall be valid for ~~a period of ten (10) years begin-~~
4 ~~ning with the date of issuance of new plates. At the end of the ninth year,~~
5 ~~the registered owner shall receive notice of the date upon which the plates~~
6 ~~will expire as long as they are readable and legible and comply with section~~
7 ~~49-428, Idaho Code. For specialty license plate programs discontinued pur-~~
8 ~~suant to the provisions of section 49-402C, Idaho Code, a registrant with a~~
9 ~~specialty license plate currently registered under the program may use such~~
10 ~~license plate for up to ten (10) years from the date of issuance as long as the~~
11 ~~license plate is readable and legible. This provision is intended to per-~~
12 ~~mit the use of the specialty plate by the registrant regardless of the num-~~
13 ~~ber of persons who purchase the specialty plate. The registrant shall be re-~~
14 ~~quired to pay the special plate program fees provided for specialty plates~~
15 ~~pursuant to this chapter. Such fees shall be deposited into the state high-~~
16 ~~way account. For purposes of section 49-434, Idaho Code, as it applies to~~
17 ~~commercial vehicles, and section 49-435, Idaho Code, the department shall~~
18 ~~provide new plates bearing the same number or, upon request from the regis-~~
19 ~~tered owner, the next available number.~~

20 (3) ~~If a license plate number has expired as provided in subsection (2)~~
21 ~~of this section and~~ registration is not renewed within sixty (60) days of its
22 expiration, the related plate number shall be available for use by another
23 registrant. To obtain a specific number in the recycled license plate num-
24 ber file, the owner of a registered vehicle may contact the county regarding
25 availability. The provisions of this subsection shall apply only to vehi-
26 cles registered under the provisions of section 49-402(1), Idaho Code, and
27 section 49-434(1), Idaho Code, as it applies to noncommercial vehicles.

28 (4) License plates issued for vehicles required to be registered in
29 accordance with the provisions of sections 49-402 and 49-402A, Idaho Code,
30 shall be issued color-coded red, white or blue registration validation
31 stickers showing the year of registration. Each registration validation
32 sticker shall bear a number from 1 through 12, which number shall correspond
33 to the month of the calendar year in which the registration of the vehicle
34 expires and shall be affixed to the lower right-hand corner of the plates
35 within the outlined rectangular area.

36 (5) License plates for utility trailers registered under the provi-
37 sions of section 49-402A, Idaho Code, that are issued for five (5) or ten (10)
38 years and license plates for rental utility trailers registered under the
39 provisions of section 49-434, Idaho Code, that are issued for up to five (5)
40 years shall use the design in effect on the date of manufacture. If a design
41 change occurs, plates from the effective date of the design change shall be
42 manufactured using the new design. Unexpired plates need not be reissued to
43 conform to a design change.

44 (6) For license plates that are lost, stolen, mutilated, or illegible,
45 the owner shall apply for a duplicate or substitute. The assessor shall also
46 furnish for each registration, and to validate the license plate, a pres-
47 sure-sensitive, uniquely numbered, color-coded red, white or blue regis-
48 tration sticker, except for trailers and semitrailers registered under the
49 provisions in section 49-434, Idaho Code. License plates issued for state,
50 county and city motor vehicles shall ~~be valid for ten (10) years pursuant~~

1 ~~to subsection (2) of this section and remain on the vehicle for which issued~~
 2 ~~from year to year and need no renewal or validation sticker.~~

3 (7) Whenever a vehicle is completely destroyed by fire or accident and
 4 the operator submits satisfactory proof of that destruction to the depart-
 5 ment or appropriate assessor's office, or the owner wishes to transfer the
 6 remaining registration, use increment and fees shall be transferred to the
 7 replacement vehicle for a service transfer fee of five dollars (\$5.00),
 8 which fee shall be retained by the registering authority. None of the orig-
 9 inal fees shall be subject to refund.

10 (8) The department shall furnish a printed or an electronic copy of the
 11 registration card to every owner whose vehicle is registered under sections
 12 49-434 and 49-435, Idaho Code.

13 (9) The board shall have authority to require the return to the depart-
 14 ment of all license plates and registration stickers upon termination of the
 15 lawful use of them by the owner.

16 (10) The board may promulgate such rules as are necessary to implement
 17 the provisions of this section.

18 SECTION 2. That Section 49-443B, Idaho Code, be, and the same is hereby
 19 amended to read as follows:

20 49-443B. LICENSE PLATES FOR STATE VEHICLES AND VEHICLES BELONGING TO
 21 TAXING DISTRICTS. (1) License plates for state vehicles and vehicles belong-
 22 ing to taxing districts shall be valid for ~~a period of ten (10) years pursuant~~
 23 ~~to such time as they are in compliance with section 49-443(2), Idaho Code,~~
 24 and shall remain on the vehicle to which it is issued until transferred to
 25 another vehicle or until it is canceled by the department. The department
 26 shall be reimbursed by state agencies and the taxing districts for the cost
 27 of providing license plates. The department may develop rules to administer
 28 this license plate program.

29 (2) Each license plate issued pursuant to this section shall bear a des-
 30 ignator to identify the agency, entity or office to which a vehicle belongs.
 31 The designators shall be as follows:

Designator	Agency, entity, office, or plate type
C	School district or miscellaneous city or county agencies, entities or offices
D	Highway district
F	Fire district
G	Fish and game
H	Department of health and welfare
ISP	Idaho state police
J	Department of commerce or department of labor
L	Law enforcement

1	P	City police
2	R	Department of parks and recreation
3	SO	Sheriff's office
4	T	Department of transportation
5	X	Miscellaneous state agencies, entities or offices
6	Y	Irrigation district
7	Z	Department of lands

8 (3) Personalized or specialty license plates are exempt from the provi-
9 sions of subsection (2) of this section.

10 SECTION 3. An emergency existing therefor, which emergency is hereby
11 declared to exist, this act shall be in full force and effect on and after
12 July 1, 2026.